Agreement as well. Though the letter didn't say it, there was a hidden threat that the Tibetans might go so far as to denounce the 1914 Convention. In the ensuing correspondence that aimed to draft a logical reply to the Tibetans, it was felt that behind everything was the fact that all Tibetan officials were looking with apprehension to the time when the Dalai Lama would come of age and they would be called to account for having acquiesced in anything which could be considered harmful to Tibet. For thirty years the British government had been inactive and there were doubts whether the British would support Tibet adequately with regard to China.

The 'big insect-small insect' quip resulted in a lot of time being devoted to the drafting of a reply to be communicated to the Tibetans by A. J. Hopkinson, special envoy of the viceroy, during his visit to Lhasa. The British said they had been Tibet's neighbours for 200 years, and had never annexed even a 'scrap of Tibetan territory'; had they indeed been 'covetous of annexing Tibetan territory, they could have easily done so in 1904'. They said firmly that '[w]hile it was true that for many years Britain did not trouble to occupy the territory in question. It made no difference to Britain's right to act as she thinks proper when she thinks proper in her own territory. Their officials have been moving forward to the frontier and will continue to move forward. The armed men who accompany those officers are not troops but a police force (Assam Rifles) for the preservation of peace and order among the tribes who inhabit the area. However, the British will not extend their activities beyond the Red Line; they will not touch one inch of Tibetan territory.'

After World War II, with the collapse of the Empire imminent, the British attitude towards Tibet promptly changed. As the British Raj entered its last few days, its tone and manner towards the Tibetans was quite different from the earlier attitude where British forces would not hesitate to bring down anything that stood in their path. In June 1945, the adviser to the Governor of Assam, J. P. Mills, prepared a top secret paper on the suitability of the Se-la range as an administrative boundary. The governor of Assam in a covering note to New Delhi concurred with Mills.

However, though there continued to be talk of 'adjusting the boundary' to suit Tibetan sentiment, no formal offer was ever made or discussed. The British, for their part, took a considered decision not to rake up the issue unless the Tibetans raised the subject. Hopkinson came to Lhasa and after spending three months holding talks with various officials on a range of